

Goodbye Laptop, Hello Smartphone!

The smartphone of the future will be able to play high-end 3D games, let you watch TV on the go, replace your credit card, help you locate your lost dog, have pro-level video cameras... And yes, you will also be able to talk!

Ram Mohan Rao

When Alexander Graham Bell invented the telephone, the first thing he said to his assistant who was two storeys away, was: "Watson, come here, I need you." In 1876, that phone was the epitome of smartness. It allowed you to do something that no one could ever do before—talk long distances without breaking your vocal cords.

One hundred and twenty-nine years later, in 2005, Bell's invention will look something like a gadget that might blow the beegesus out of the loyal PC (and a lot of other gadgets). Your humble cell phone will allow you to browse the Web at high speeds, send e-mail, click photos, scan pictures and send them 3,000 miles across the globe, instruct your air-conditioner to start 10 minutes before you reach home, play high-end 3D games, watch TV, replace your credit card by paying your bills at the mall, help you locate your lost dog, read a book of your choice while you are travelling, listen to your MP3s at high bitrates for crystal clear sound... The list—and it is not even a wish list—could go on and on.

Oh, by the way, you will also be able to talk using the phone.

By the time you read this, we are already half-way into getting such a smart device out into the market. But that is the key phrase—half-way.



Petfrog

Petfrog, the device featured in the picture alongside, is an 'Integrated Fusion Device' of the future as envisaged by Frog Design, a US-based design company. Petfrog is the first wireless communication and computing concept with integrated hardware, software, and content user-interface. It is a PDA, personal computer, digital media player, camera, karaoke machine, and more. All functionality converges into one seamless platform resulting in an 'all-in-one gadget'.

Cell as credit card, and more

NTT DoCoMo, Japan's premier mobile service provider, debuted their cell phone-as-a-credit-card prototype in June, but it will be some time before cell phones replace the credit card. That's where the problem lies. The features are scattered, and no single device has yet incorporated all the features. When that happens—and it is only a matter of time—your laptop just may become redundant. Perhaps a few other devices, too.

Today's high-end smartphones are equivalent to the 486 PC you used eight years ago. The new-age smartphone will have immense processing power, and playing high-end 3D games by the end of 2006 will be passé. This means that RAM

Model: Ashu Kakkar Photo: Mery Xavier Imaging Parag Joshi

? Rings a bell?

The phone of the future will allow you to:

- ❑ Browse for movies, music, photos and slide shows right from your TV.
- ❑ Listen to your MP3 collection on your home stereo.
- ❑ Watch feature-length movies from the Internet in the comfort of your living room.
- ❑ Use catalogs to quickly access related content.
- ❑ Synchronise - Connect to your Windows-based PC and you can take your content on the go with you.
- ❑ Publish - Using the Content Server on your PC, publish catalogs to other users.
- ❑ Browse - Browse through your content on more than one PC or a network.

